

DELHI | Floating Weapon

It may be named after a mythological flying elephant, but the *Airavat* is making a big statement on water. The Indian Navy's new Landing Ship Tank (Large), *Airavat* is the fifth in a series of such indigenously-built warships. When the first

ship was acquired in the 1990s, it was purely a 5,655-tonne platform meant for ferrying troops and tanks. But in a measure of the navy's changing role in the decades since, the *Airavat*, named after Indra's elephant, is a multi-mission ship, quite like a maritime Swiss army knife. It can carry 10 battle tanks and 500 troops, be used as a fleet tanker to refuel ships at sea and as a hospital ship. Based with the eastern fleet in Visakhapatnam, the 125-m *Airavat* doubles up to provide humanitarian assistance and disaster relief during crises like the tsunami. It can operate on the high seas for 45 days at a stretch. Its rocket launchers, anti-aircraft guns and shoulder-fired surface-to-air missiles and a Sea King helicopter makes it a formidable war machine. The *Airavat*'s has smoke curtains to impede the spreading of smoke and toxic gases in case of fire. **by Sandeep Unnithan**



THE AIRAVAT

Clan Plan

You wouldn't think so after the DMK's strong showing in Tamil Nadu, but supremo M. Karunanidhi has struggled to keep his vast clan together as his numerous kith and kin clamoured for a cabinet berth as their fair share of the spoils of the electoral war.

DELHI | Reservation Rigmarole

The UPA's election victory has India Inc rushing to remind the new government about the pending reforms. All except one: legislation to impose reservation in the private sector. The new government may have its focus on manufacturing and jobs but India Inc is taking no chances. They are already in 'affirmative action' mode to checkmate the impending legislation forcing actual numbers and percentages on them. Human resource professionals in manufacturing, hospitality, engineering, automobile and other labour intensive industries such as textiles, gems and jewellery and units engaged in assemblies have started counting the numbers of Scheduled Castes/Scheduled Tribes and candidates from other backward communities employed at lower and clerical levels. The idea is to show the government that the private sector has already employed a good number of candidates of SC/ST and backward communities in their units. **by Nivedita Mukherjee**



A PROTEST AGAINST RESERVATION IN THE PRIVATE SECTOR

DELHI |

Search Party

The counting of votes for the 15th General Election to the Lok Sabha also became an occasion to reveal another popular choice: the source of news. As India tallied its votes, Google Hot Trends India reports that the second most searched word for May 16 was "Aaj Tak" after "Election 2009". In the top 100 keywords for the day, variants of 'Aaj Tak' featured four times—"aaj tak", "aajtak news", "ajtak" and "aajtak tv live", and put together, "Aaj Tak" could



have been the most searched for term online for Indian poll news. This, with extensive channel promos, resulted in heavy traffic on the Aaj Tak website (www.aajtak.in). Each visitor to the website spent on an average 14 minutes; extremely high in the Internet space. India Today Group Editor-in-Chief Aron Purie says, "When it comes to hard news and breaking news, Aaj Tak is the first choice, regardless of medium. It reaffirms Aaj Tak's leadership position over the last decade."